of all inevitably that authoritarian government which the Viceroy represented in his person and which could do what it chose anywhere in India. In any democratic or semi-democratic country such a calamity would have swept away all the governments concerned with it. Not so in India where everything continued as before.

Considered even from the point of view of the war, this famine took place in the very region which stood nearest to the theatre of war and possible invasion. A widespread famine and collapse of the economic structure would inevitably injure the capacity for defence and even more so for offence. Thus did the Government of India discharge its responsibility for India's defence and the prosecution of the war against the Japanese aggressors. Not scorched earth but scorched and starved and dead human beings

cent of the people of Bengal suffered from major diseases. Official figures of the Bengal

Government, based largely on unreliable reports from village patwaris or headmen, gave a

much lower figure. The official Famine Inquiry Commission, presided over by Sir John

Woodhead, has come to the conclusion that about 1,500,000 deaths occurred in Bengal 'as